

DANCE



WHEN PEOPLE MOVE in time to music they are dancing. People have a natural urge to move in time to rhythms. Children jump up and down when they are excited; babies move naturally to rhythms they hear or feel. In dancing, these natural movements are organized into rhythmic and visual patterns. Different dances have developed all over the world, and are performed for different reasons. Dancing can be both an art form and recreation. It can express an emotion, tell a story, or set a mood.

Origins

Dancing is one of the oldest art forms. The first dances may have evolved from spontaneous stamping steps. These steps were later given rhythms and shapes and accompanied by grunts and shouts.



Australian Aboriginals performing the corroboree

Ceremonial dance
Early people found that rhythmic movements had a strong effect on the mind, and felt that dancing must have magical powers. They began to dance to ward off evil spirits, heal people, and ensure good crops.

Dance as entertainment

The ancient Egyptians were the first people known to use dancing simply as a form of entertainment. Professional dancing girls entertained the pharaoh and his guests at banquets, performing dances that included running, high kicks, and sensual hip movements.



Ancient Egyptian dancing girls



Chorus depicted on a Greek vase

Dance as theatre

The ancient Greeks made dance the basis of all their theatre. The chorus in a Greek play was a group of actors who danced and sang a commentary on the action.



Maasai dancers

The Maasai of East Africa move in straight lines as they dance, and include high jumps in their routines. As happens in all African dance, they are accompanied by rhythmic, exhilarating drumbeats.

African dance

Dancing is an essential part of life to many Africans, and important events, such as births, deaths, and initiation to adulthood, are all observed by dancing. African dances can last for many hours. The dances for men are usually very energetic, and include a lot of stamping and leaping. Women tend to do more gentle dances, clapping and swaying to the music or rhythm.

Asian dancing

The main influence on dance styles in Asia comes from India. Many Asian dances make use of stylized hand movements, particularly those from countries such as India, Sri Lanka, Burma, Thailand, and Cambodia.



Dragon

The mythical dragon is a very important symbol in Chinese culture. Dragon dances are performed to celebrate festivals such as the Chinese New Year.

Dancers wear a dragon costume.



Head-dress

Bent-back fingers

Indian dances

Indian classical dancers mime out stories from Indian mythology, and include sequences of more abstract dance movements.



There are six styles of Indian classical dance.

Southeast Asian dances

Classical dance in Southeast Asia typically includes slow, controlled movements, with many graceful hand and arm gestures. Dance-dramas, performed by highly trained dancers, are particularly popular in Indonesia and Thailand. Throughout the region there is a wide variety of traditional folk dances.

Royal Thai classical dancer

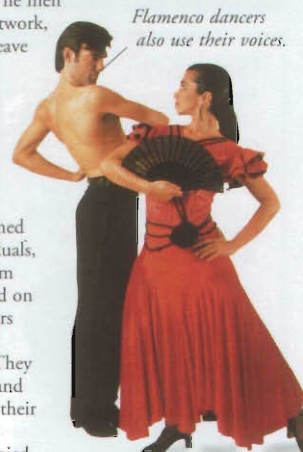
European folk dancing

Every European country has its folk dances, which are now essentially social. Some of them have been taken to other countries by settlers. The dances are often performed in traditional costumes, and many of them involve people forming simple patterns, such as lines and circles.



Flamenco

Perhaps the most famous of all Spanish dances is the flamenco. This dance is a mixture of both the Spanish and Arab cultures. The men use complicated footwork, while the women weave patterns with their arms. The dancers are accompanied by fast, dramatic guitar music.



Flamenco dancers also use their voices.

Irish dancing

Irish jigs are usually performed either by pairs or by individuals, but large groups also perform Irish dances. The jig is based on simple steps, but the dancers can elaborate and perform complicated leaping steps. They hold their upper body still and their arms straight down at their sides or holding hands. The dances are usually accompanied by the fiddle or bagpipes.